

GULF STATES



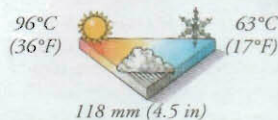
SAUDI ARABIA, Yemen, Oman, Kuwait, United Arab Emirates, Qatar, and Bahrain – make up the Arabian Peninsula. Six

of these countries – all except Yemen – have coastlines on the Gulf and are often called the Gulf States. As a result of the rich oil deposits in the region – about half the world's total – many of these countries are wealthy, and the region is politically very important. In the past 50 years, there has been great industrial and social change in what was an underdeveloped region. Even so, most of the land is uninhabited.



Yemeni Mountains

These rugged mountains in the west of Yemen reach a height of 3,760 m (12,336 ft). The western slopes are well watered by rain blowing in from the Red Sea and are extensively cultivated by terracing. The climate is ideal for growing coffee, grapes, and cotton.



Regional climate

Most of the region is very dry and hot all year, although winter temperatures in northern Saudi Arabia and Kuwait may drop below freezing. Only southwest Saudi Arabia and north Yemen receive rain. Some desert areas have no rain for years at a time.

Islam

For almost 1,500 years, Islam has been the dominant religion in the Gulf States. Muslims, the followers of Islam, believe in one god, Allah, and the prophet Muhammad, who was born in the Saudi Arabian town of Mecca. In many countries, life is interrupted five times a day while people pray.



Worshippers outside the mosque, Dubai

Physical features

Nearly all of the Arabian Peninsula is dry desert, sandy or rocky, with some rugged, bare mountains near the coast. There are small fertile areas along the coasts, in some mountain regions, and at oases. Most of the fresh water for cities and industry comes from large desalination plants that remove salt from and purify sea water from the Gulf.



Red Sea

The warm, salty waters of the narrow Red Sea, 2,000 km (1,243 miles) long, separate Africa from Asia. The Red Sea is connected to the Mediterranean Sea by the Suez Canal, which was built in 1869 to provide a route for ships between Europe and eastern Asia.



Najd Desert

The Najd is a vast area of stony desert plateau at the heart of Saudi Arabia. Some Najdi people still live here, leading a semi-nomadic existence tending camels and sheep, although many are moving into towns. Saudi Arabia's largest desert is the uninhabited Rub' al Khali, in the south, known as the "Empty Quarter".

